

Fig. 10.5: Worshipping monks in front of Lumbini’s Ashokan pillar

As for the temple, before Ashoka at least two construction phases have been unearthed which included brick pavements and a kerb. A series of postholes below these pavements and kerb defined a sacred space going back to the sixth century BCE, possibly earlier.[29] Within the open centre of this area, substantial root features were located which the excavators interpreted as representing the remnants of a tree shrine. If so, this is possibly the first tree shrine to have been identified at a Buddhist place of worship, a feature which became much more common subsequently in the form of Bodhigrihas (shrines around living trees).

Large additions were made to the temple in Mauryan times, in two stages of construction.[30] One of these saw the erection of a rectangular temple or chaitya whose foundation trench had a filling of material that is thought to be Mauryan. The superstructure was apparently of timber. After this, the